TRIESTE. At Trieste, the prison consists of eight or ten very close offensive rooms, each having only one small window. The pale countenances of the (nineteen) prisoners bespoke their own misery, and the negligence of the magistrates and keepers.

But in the castle were eighty-five slaves (*condannati*) who seemed healthy and well. They were confined for three, five, seven, or fourteen years and upwards; and were employed on the roads, in the harbour, etc. Some of them were at work in a large lighter, clearing the harbour, just under my chamber window.[1] They were guarded by six soldiers. They did not work harder than other labourers would in the same employment. Their hours for work were from five in the morning till between five and six in the afternoon; but they had two (from eleven to one) allowed them for rest, and half an hour more sometime before they left work. They appeared healthy, clean and strong; and laboured cheerfully, because when they were employed, each of them received, as extraordinary pay, three farthings a day. They were distinguished from other labourers by a light chain on their legs. Their common allowance was two pounds and a half of bread and four farthings a day. I heard them called over, and saw them receive their pay, before they entered their chambers in the castle. Their bread was sweet and good. They were treated with humanity, though under strict discipline; were well supplied with food and clothes; had two shirts, two pairs of stockings, etc., and they lay in good beds with coverlets in large airy rooms having opposite windows, and not, like many convicts, in close dirty dungeons, under the fortifications.

[1] Two wheels were fixed in the lighter, one of them to draw back the scoop or bucket, and the other (by the weight of ten men treading in it) to raise the mud, which was then emptied into another lighter managed by the overseer of the work. Three or four times a day, a soldier (with a bayonet fixed on his musket) accompanied a convict, who went to fetch a tub of fresh water, and on his return he supplied each with a tumbler of it while they were at work in the wheel. By the mast of the other lighter, a sail was spread to shade them, the weather being very warm, Farenheit's thermometer 85°.

ITALY

I entered Italy in 1778 with raised expectations of considerable information, from a careful attention to the prisons and hospitals, in a country abounding with charitable institutions and public edifices.

VENICE. At Venice, the chief prison is near the Doge's palace,[1] and it is one of the strongest I ever saw. There were between three and four hundred prisoners, many of them confined in loathsome and dark cells for life; executions here being very rare. There was no fever, or prevailing disorder in this close prison. None of the prisoners had irons. On weighing the bread allowance, I found it fourteen ounces. I asked some who had been confined many years in dark cells, whether they would prefer the galleys? They all answered in the affirmative: so great a blessing is light and air! The chapel is for the condemned, who continue there a night and a day before execution.

Regulations were hung up in the prison. Here is a charitable society established for the relief of prisoners both civil and criminal, and rules are published for the direction of the officers who have the management of it, of whom four are appointed visitors of the prison. There are likewise rules for the good government of the two infirmaries. These I procured from the ducal printer, with the regulations for the galleys and prisons, for many years past.

One of the galleys was moored two boats' length from the shore, in which were only twenty-seven slaves, who were kept here in order to be sent on board the other galleys. This was clean. Here, and in the other galleys, which were dirty and crowded, the slaves were in chains of about twenty-seven pounds weight. I saw a slave dead on the shore, who I suppose destroyed himself in despair; as he could have no hope of an escape by swimming, because of his heavy irons.

PADUA. I visited the prisons of Padua and Ferrara. In the former of these cities, none of the confined debtors would sit on the elevated stone stool in the great hall: and I was informed that not one had submitted to the ignominy these ten years.[2]

[1] The rooms for the State prisoners are over part of the palace on the leads, which renders confinement in the heat of summer almost intolerable.

[2] This is sometimes called the stone of disgrace; for if they who are insolvent would avoid imprisonment, at a time fixed they must sit upon it in a disgraceful manner three times.